

10 questions to ask before you sign.

Updated July 2026 · hakadecks.com/questions-to-ask-your-deck-builder

About to sign a deck contract? Ask these ten questions first, whoever the builder is. They take five minutes, they expose the weak bids fast, and any builder worth hiring will enjoy answering them. Bring this sheet to every estimate — including ours.

01 Can I see the bid itemized?

Why it matters: a lump-sum number can't be compared to anything, and change orders have nowhere honest to land.

A good answer: line items for plans and permits, demo, footings, framing, decking, railing, and stairs — so two bids can be compared line for line.

02 Who pulls the permit — you or me?

Why it matters: a builder who pushes the permit onto you (or suggests skipping it) is a builder whose work has never been inspected.

A good answer: "We do — drawings, submission, inspections, and corrections." Full stop.

03 What's the footing and framing spec?

Why it matters: "per code" with no numbers is a shrug in writing. Colorado decks need frost-depth footings and snow-load framing.

A good answer: actual numbers — footing depth and diameter, joist size and spacing, and how the ledger will be flashed and fastened.

04 Are you licensed and insured — and can I see it?

Why it matters: if anything goes wrong on your property, the builder's general liability and workers' comp are what stand between the incident and your homeowner's policy.

A good answer: certificates on request without flinching, naming real coverage amounts.

05 Who is actually on my site each day?

Why it matters: some outfits sell the job and subcontract the build. You're hiring the crew, not the brochure.

A good answer: a named crew and a named point of contact — and you met them during the estimate. Pete walks every Haka project personally.

06 What manufacturer certifications do you hold?

Why it matters: certification tiers aren't wall decoration — they unlock longer labor-coverage warranty terms from the board manufacturer, at no cost to you.

A good answer: named tiers (ours: Deckorators Pro Elite, Trex Platinum Pro, TimberTech dealer) and what each unlocks.

07 What's your written workmanship warranty?

Why it matters: the boards carry 25–50 year manufacturer warranties; the structure underneath only carries what the builder puts in writing.

A good answer: a term in writing (ours is 2 years), what it covers, and a straight answer about how claims have actually been handled.

08 What's the payment schedule?

Why it matters: a deposit should cover materials mobilization, not shift the job's whole risk onto you before a post is set.

A good answer: a modest deposit, payments tied to milestones, and the balance due at the final walkthrough — never half down.

09 What's the realistic timeline — in writing?

Why it matters: "we can start next week" usually means the permit hasn't been thought about. Front Range approvals run 2–4 weeks.

A good answer: a written schedule that includes the permit window, the on-site days, and what happens when weather interrupts.

10 Can I see recent local work and talk to those homeowners?

Why it matters: photos prove taste; addresses and referrals prove the work holds up through a Colorado winter.

A good answer: projects you can drive past, reviews you can read, and past clients who'll take your call.

Red-flag shorthand, if you only remember three: a lump-sum bid, "half down," and "you can pull the permit yourself to save money." Any one of them is your cue to keep shopping. — Haka Decks · 720-589-5680